

Getting out of this trap requires a significant shift in thinking.

BUILDING AN ADAPTIVE ORGANIZATION

Should a startup invest in a training program for new employees? If you had asked me a few years ago, I would have laughed and said, “Absolutely not. Training programs are for big companies that can afford them.” Yet at IMVU we wound up building a training program that was so good, new hires were productive on their first day of employment. Within just a few weeks, those employees were contributing at a high level. It required a huge effort to standardize our work processes and prepare a curriculum of the concepts that new employees should learn. Every new engineer would be assigned a mentor, who would help the new employee work through a curriculum of systems, concepts, and techniques he or she would need to become productive at IMVU. The performance of the mentor and mentee were linked, so the mentors took this education seriously.

What is interesting, looking back at this example, is that we never stopped work and decided that we needed to build a great training program. Instead, the training program evolved organically out of a methodical approach to evolving our own process. This process of orientation was subject to constant experimentation and revision so that it grew more effective—and less burdensome—over time.

I call this building an adaptive organization, one that automatically adjusts its process and performance to current conditions.

Can You Go Too Fast?

So far this book has emphasized the importance of speed. Startups are in a life-or-death struggle to learn how to build a sustainable business before they run out of resources and die. However, focusing on speed alone would be destructive. To work, startups